✦ STEP 7

Cross-Ex Practice

Questions the other side might ask you. Answer out loud first, then open the model answer.

⚠ **USE YOUR OWN WORDS**

The model answers show the **idea**. In a round you can't read from notes, so practice saying each answer your own way.

💡 **RULE #1 OF CROSS-EX**

Never accept their version of the facts. If a question ends with "*right?*", watch out. It's a trap to make you agree. Fix the false part first, then answer.

✧ When you're Affirmative

✦ **"In 2023 Somaliland lost Las Anod. So it doesn't control its territory, right?"**

"**No.** Somaliland still controls most of its land, including its capital and its main port. And recognized countries have border disputes too: India and Pakistan both claim Kashmir. That isn't a reason to deny recognition."

✦ **"The U.S. recognizes lots of countries that aren't democracies. Why does democracy matter?"**

"Democracy isn't the only reason. It's one good reason among several. Somaliland also meets the Montevideo test and sits in a key location." *(When they attack one reason, don't over-defend it. Point to your others.)*

- **"The U.S. doesn't recognize Taiwan either. So why would siding with Taiwan earn Somaliland recognition?"**

  "The U.S. doesn't officially recognize Taiwan, but it still supports Taiwan strongly. Somaliland took a real risk to stand with a U.S. friend, and partners who take risks for us deserve support."

- **"Somaliland chose to join Somalia in 1960. Why should it get to leave?"**

  "The union was never properly ratified, and northerners voted against the 1961 constitution. And choosing to join doesn't mean accepting being bombed by your own government. Somalia broke the deal."

- **"Can't the U.S. just use Berbera without recognizing Somaliland?"**

  "For short visits, maybe. But a real long-term base deal needs an official agreement with a recognized government. Without one, any deal can be dropped at any time."

- **"Your Heritage evidence is from 2021. Isn't it outdated?"**

  "The key facts haven't changed. China's base is still in Djibouti, right next to ours. Old evidence is fine when the facts are still true."

- **"The African Union says recognizing Somaliland is a dangerous precedent. Aren't they the experts on Africa?"**

  "The AU's own fact-finding mission in 2005 called Somaliland's case 'historically unique and self-justified.' The AU just never acted on its own report."

When you're Negative

- **"Somaliland meets all four Montevideo criteria. Isn't it already a country?"**

  "Even if it acts like one, recognition is a **choice** the U.S. makes based on its interests. And Somaliland doesn't control all the land it claims, as Las Anod shows."

✦ **"Somalia needs U.S. help against al-Shabaab. It would never cut ties, right?"**

"**Not necessarily.** Somalia doesn't have to fully cut ties to hurt us. It could limit where U.S. forces operate, or turn to Turkey, Egypt or China. Why take the chance?"

✦ **"How would recognizing Somaliland hurt Americans?"**

"If Somalia stops working with the U.S. against al-Shabaab, the group could grow stronger in East Africa and put Americans there at risk." *(Don't say "terrorism in the U.S." You can't prove it.)*

✦ **"Eritrea and South Sudan broke away and Africa was fine. Why would Somaliland be different?"**

"Both held independence referendums that the country they left agreed to: Ethiopia accepted Eritrea's vote in 1993, and Sudan accepted South Sudan's in 2011 under a 2005 peace deal. Somalia has never agreed to let Somaliland go. Recognizing it anyway would mean taking sides in an unresolved dispute."

✦ **"The U.S. recognized Kosovo even though Serbia objected. Why not Somaliland?"**

"Kosovo was backed by most of Europe and NATO. With Somaliland, almost no one is on board. Even after Israel recognized it, not a single other country followed. The U.S. would be nearly alone."

✦ **"Your CRS evidence never says recognition would end the partnership. So where's the risk?"**

"It shows how much the fight depends on Somalia's cooperation: over 130 coordinated strikes in one year. And the White House itself warned in 2024 that a recognition deal 'threatens to disrupt the fight' against al-Shabaab."